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IN TANDEM: Police officials led by (from left) Pande and Asthana moved swiftly to nab SIMI activists across the country

THE COUNTDOWN TO THE AHMEDABAD BLASTS BEGAN IN DECEMBER LAST IN A FULL-FLEDGED TERROR CAMP IN THE WAGAMON JUNGLES OF KERALA WHERE OVER 35 BOYS WERE TRAINED IN TERRORIST ACTIVITIES.

unsolved blast cases involving SIMI.

One of the main factors that led to the cracking of the case was the analysis of 125 GB of mobile phone data by the Gujarat Police and forensic experts. They tracked calls made between July 23 and July 26 from five phones, which were switched off at 4 p.m. on July 26, less than three hours before the blasts. The sleuths also matched the phone data with the movement of the two cars that came to Ahmedabad on July 9 and 17 respectively from towards Mumbai. These cars were used in the Civil Hospital and the LG Hospital in Ahmedabad. While on roaming, the five mobile phones could only receive calls, which all came from STD booths.

Incidentally, SIMI's funding remains a mystery, with most of its money coming from secret donations. One of its main donors is believed to be a Gujarat-based Muslim businessman who is very close to a top politician of a national secular party. The strategic training given to SIMI cadres teaches them to pick up journalism and legal professions. The countdown to the Ahmedabad blasts began in December last when Nagori and his brother Kamruddin Nagori organised a full-fledged training camp for the SIMI cadres in the Wagamon jungles near Idduki in Kerala. The camp trained over 35 boys in terrorist activities inflamed by fiery speeches from Bashir. This was the third camp to be held under Nagori's direction after he fell out in 2006 with Mizbul Haq, a moderate who was against his aim to plunge into terrorism. Haq had taken over as president (jimme-

war) from Shahid Badr Falahi in 2006. Haq wanted SIMI to join politics while Nagori wanted to turn to terrorism. The two parted ways and the majority went along with Nagori who rechristened SIMI as IM. The earlier three camps were held under Nagori's leadership at Castle Rock near Hubli in April 2007, in Dharwad district of Karnataka in August 2007 and in Choral near Indore in November 2007.

The terror camp in the Pavagadh jungles near Vadodara in January was crucial for the Ahmedabad attacks. It trained nearly 24 SIMI activists, including 16 from Gujarat, of whom most

have been arrested. Here, the blue print for the Ahmedabad and Surat blasts started taking shape, a theme that had been initiated at the Wagamon camp. But for Nagori's arrest along with his brother in March, Ahmedabad and Surat would have been hit probably in February-end or in March.

With Nagori's departure, SIMI's leadership passed on to Bashir and Tauqir, who started putting the plan in shape. In April-end or May, they rented two houses in Ahmedabad and another in Bharuch, which has emerged as a key centre of Deobandi radicalism in Gujarat. Mansuri, a native of Surat, too had moved to Bharuch around the same time.

There is great excitement in the Gujarat Police and security agencies about the early success in the investigation which is like a first in India's history of tackling terror. Says Gujarat Director-General of Police, P.C. Pande, "We have strong evidence to pin them down on charges of conspiracy and execution. There are still some loose ends which need to be tied up." What is significant is the fact that the Ahmedabad blasts probe has opened the doors for tracking the roots of home-grown jihad. Close on the heels of the indications that Mansuri and Imran had played key roles in the Jaipur blasts, the Rajasthan Police nabbed 17 SIMI activists including two doctors. Tauqir is now the man being chased. The country could still contain the menace of terrorism if it follows the path shown by Gujarat.

with Subhash Mishra